

Whether it's a loaded or a non-loaded fund, the fees are going to be about the same over any five-year period.

I personally prefer the non-loaded fund because it allows my money to be earning dividends without the service fees or commissions coming out of the initial investment. But if you decide to withdraw your money during the first five years, even a non-loaded fund will charge a penalty to cover their fees. Obviously they have administrative overhead and commissions to recover. Income potential, 5-7. Risk, 4-5.

COMMON STOCKS: As discussed earlier, one advantage of common stocks is that you can invest with a relatively small amount of money and potential exists for sizable growth. The liabilities of common stocks are obvious. First, you can suffer a loss as easily as you can make a profit. Second, stocks require buying and selling to maximize their potential. Most people think they can put their money into a stock and just let it sit without having to manage it. But that is rarely the case today. If you expect to make money in the stock market, you're going to have to manage it. If you're not willing to do that, it's best to stay with other investments. Income potential, 2-8. Risk, 7-8.

PRECIOUS METALS: Precious metals such as gold, silver, or platinum can be purchased either for long-term growth or pure speculation. Long-term growth really means that you buy the metal, put it into a safety-deposit box, and let it appreciate (hopefully) for a period of time. The majority of people who do this do so primarily as a hedge against a potential calamity in the economy. I would counsel most investors to put a small amount of their assets in precious metals. In an economy as unstable as ours, they can be a good balance to assets more vulnerable to inflation. When buying and selling anything, especially precious metals, it always is wise to remember what Baruch said: "Buy when they sell. Sell when they buy." Keep a long-term mentality about precious metals, at least those you invest in as a hedge.

Both gold and silver fluctuate with the economy. Gold usually cycles faster and further than silver, primarily because more